Dilip Chakrabarti, Jairam Ramesh, Rakesh Tiwari, Vivek Suneja, and Upinder Singh for reading and critiquing parts of the manuscript. Ella Datta’s advice on acquiring images was tremendously helpful. Kesavan Veluthat and Shalini Shah in Delhi and Parimal Rupani in Junagadh provided some important references, and Suryanarayana Nanda guided me through the inscriptions of Ashoka. I must also acknowledge the two anonymous reviewers who read the manuscript for Permanent Black and Harvard University Press with great care and insight. Some of their suggestions have improved the narrative in many ways.

At the various places where I pursued this research, I owe a profound debt to many institutions and people, especially the officers of the Archaeological Survey of India: in Junagadh, Rasik Bhatt, J.P. Bhatt, M. Sutaria, and K.C. Nauriyal; in Nepal, Hari D. Rai; in Karnataka and Andhra, S.V.P. Hallakati and Srinivas; in Uttar Pradesh, Subhash Yadav; in Madhya Pradesh, S.B. Ota; in Delhi, V.N. Prabhakar, the staff of the Archaeological Survey of India library, especially Satpal Singh, and Dr Narendra Kumar at the Central Library of the University of Delhi.

Because of the disappearance of high editorial skills in book publishing nowadays, Rukun Advani is already the subject of folklore among the discerning. The reason, in my experience, has to do with his breadth of knowledge and the surgical skill with which he transforms scripts when he relates well to them and their authors. His imagination and precision have made doing books with him the most intensely enjoyable experience of my professional life, and this book has been no different. His interest in the sound and music of prose as part of the art of writing well has also sustained me in numerous ways. For adding lightness to the often ponderous pen of a professional archaeologist, and much else, this book is dedicated to him.

At a purely personal level my greatest debt is to Kishore Lahiri for a lifetime of encouragement and support. This book is dedicated to the three